

increasing dependence on the digital medium, IT security has become very important. Any and every industry which has data at rest or data in motion can be a victim. In this scenario, IT security professionals are the guardians of such data.

For someone who's interested, IT security is perhaps the most upcoming and challenging option available. Unlike other branches of IT, security is relatively impervious to recessionary upheavals. Besides, jobs in the software or programming domain can become monotonous. Chances are high that a person who enters as a Java, Cobol or C programmer will end up doing just that all through his career. "Whereas security is an evergreen field" says Rakesh Goyal. "As long as there will be information and digital assets, as long as there are people after these assets, there is bound to be a need for IT security professionals," he adds. Rakesh Goyal has been a veteran of IT security since 18 years with six books and 50 research papers under his belt. He is the Managing Director of Sysman Computers Private Limited and Director-General, Centre for Research and Prevention of Computer Crimes. "Five different levels of encryption algorithms were recently broken by leveraging the increase in computing power of new age processors," he informed us. Every assignment is new and every experience is a learning experience. Hackers are finding holes in everything, so professionals either have to be reactive or proactive. Being reactive you have to respond to attacks and plug those holes, and when proactive you have to think ahead of these miscreants. "The demand is increasing and there is a shortage so naturally I don't need to mention that salaries are higher", says Goyal. "Salary-wise professionals here command salaries that are least 1.5 to 2 times higher than the regular programmers."

The roadmap

Like any industry, there are some entry barriers and prerequisites in the form of certifications and qualifications. Yet, it turns out that IT security is pretty open. "There are commonly known security certifications like CISSP from (ISC)2, GCIA, GCIH from GIAC which are widely accepted as entrance criteria. However, candidates with strong computer networking fundamentals and an inclination towards reverse engineering technology have a very good chance of succeeding in the industry," says Shantanu Ghosh, Managing Director - India, Product Operations, Symantec Software India Pvt Ltd.

CEH (Certified Ethical Hacking) is an entry-level certification for awareness of different mechanisms used to compromise networks. There